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Hidden Light of the Feminine





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Femininity through the Prism of Chinese Characters

a constant motion between genre & ink

SLIDE 1 | Chinese characters have existed since immemorial times. They have undergone a fascinating evolution through time. Some writings retrace them and are precious relics of the many eras these writings have gone through.

Chinese writing began at the end of the 2nd millennium BC with writing in oracle bone, engraved on animal bones, turtle breastplates, or other supports that nature offered to these first scribes.

These "pictogram" writings were initially - hence their name - made of small bones or branches, which drew what the scribes saw in the world around them. Later, they were transformed into engravings on supports. Over time, they evolved into simplified forms - or not - ideograms and pictograms.

Subsequently, these writings evolved into an ancient art of 7,000 years, according to some historians (older by 1,500 years compared to Sumerian cuneiform writing): The calligraphic art, which became one of the major arts of the court with rapid expansion, as well as one of the oldest forms of Chinese artistic expression along with painting.

Calligraphy is an integral part of Chinese heritage and Hong Kong, which still uses traditional signs. Hong Kong does not use the simplified Chinese introduced in mainland China in 1956 to make writing more accessible. The latter may be decried by the guardians of the heritage of Chinese writing, which has one of the oldest and richest histories and must be preserved within societies.

SLIDE 2 | Looking back at archive images and films of Hong Kong in the 1960s and 1970s, one is surprised by the multitude of brightly coloured neon lights decorating the city's bustling streets. It is also clear that the script used is traditional Chinese, with its incredibly graphic signs. It is also present in countries such as Japan, where they are called "kanji", pronounced in different phonetic variants.

To say, only by these few examples, the infinite richness of this writing system...

SLIDE 3 | The Chinese character of a woman is no exception in this long evolution. And, in the context of our theme, "feminity in motion", it is interesting to observe the evolution and - equally - the perception of this character.

In many works, the character, as it is designated, is transcribed by a kneeling woman. According to some sinologists, this is justified by a culture that assigns women the role of obedient beings, kneeling before the patriarch of the household (father, husband, or emperor).

However, some researchers and artists have explored alternative perceptions: the strong, liberated woman who stands up and walks with a firm step, guided by her own decisions.

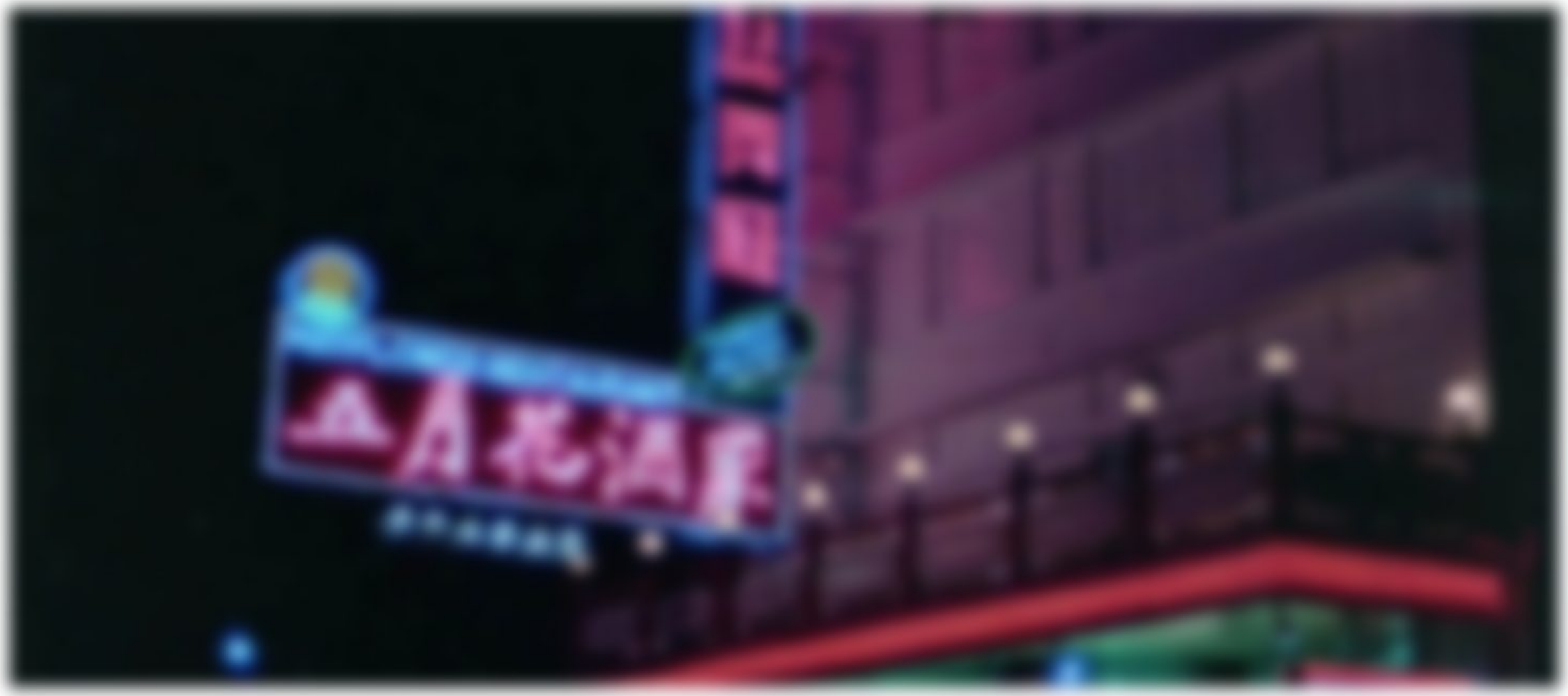
If we explore the history of women in ancient China, we find the representation of Zheng Mao, wife of King Cheng of Chu State. In this representation, the husband kneels, and his wife advises him on implementing political and geopolitical strategies.

The Chinese intellectual Pan Hoei Pan also appears to be kneeling. However, she is raising her hand to turn the book she is studying.

In the illustration of the T'ang dynasty female musicians, a woman is shown kneeling. However, she is kneeling to perform, to play her instrument, and to practice her art.

The perception of gender, therefore, plays a very important role in her interpretation and can be explored through new prisms...

SLIDE 4 | The strength of the art of calligraphy is such that it has left many artists unmoved, including Echo Morgan and Kaihuan Feng, who express the fragility of the body through its practice, Lin Hwai-Min, who explores calligraphy in relation to natural elements and bodies in motion, Tomowo Kawao, who defends the heritage of this ancestral art that must not disappear, and Kanazawa Shoko who, with her Down syndrome, has found in calligraphy a way to express all the fragility but also the power of her being.


月花温泉

Bestiary of the Feminine

The wild woman & her inner cosmos

SLIDE 1 | In ancient times, our ancestors - devoid of mobile phones, screens and light pollution - carefully observed the sky, telling stories about those distant stars in constant motion. These 'stargazing' stories - nowadays much less common, yet still shared by communities of enthusiasts - played a central and consequential role in everyone's life.

It is interesting to note that events such as the appearance of a comet were so important that they can still be found in works of art today.

In the Adoration of the Magi, Giotto reproduced the appearance of the Halley comet, which crossed the European sky in 1301. At that time, such an event must have astounded several generations.

The last appearance of Comet Halley, seen from Earth every 76 years, was in 1987. Today, if we ask the generations that could have seen it, few remember it or even observed it...

SLIDE 2 | The observation of stars has been the subject of numerous discoveries, breathtaking inventions - such as the Antikythera mechanism - to calculate their positions, observatories, books and disciplines mixing astronomy and astrology; at times when the now commonly spread split between fields did not yet exist...

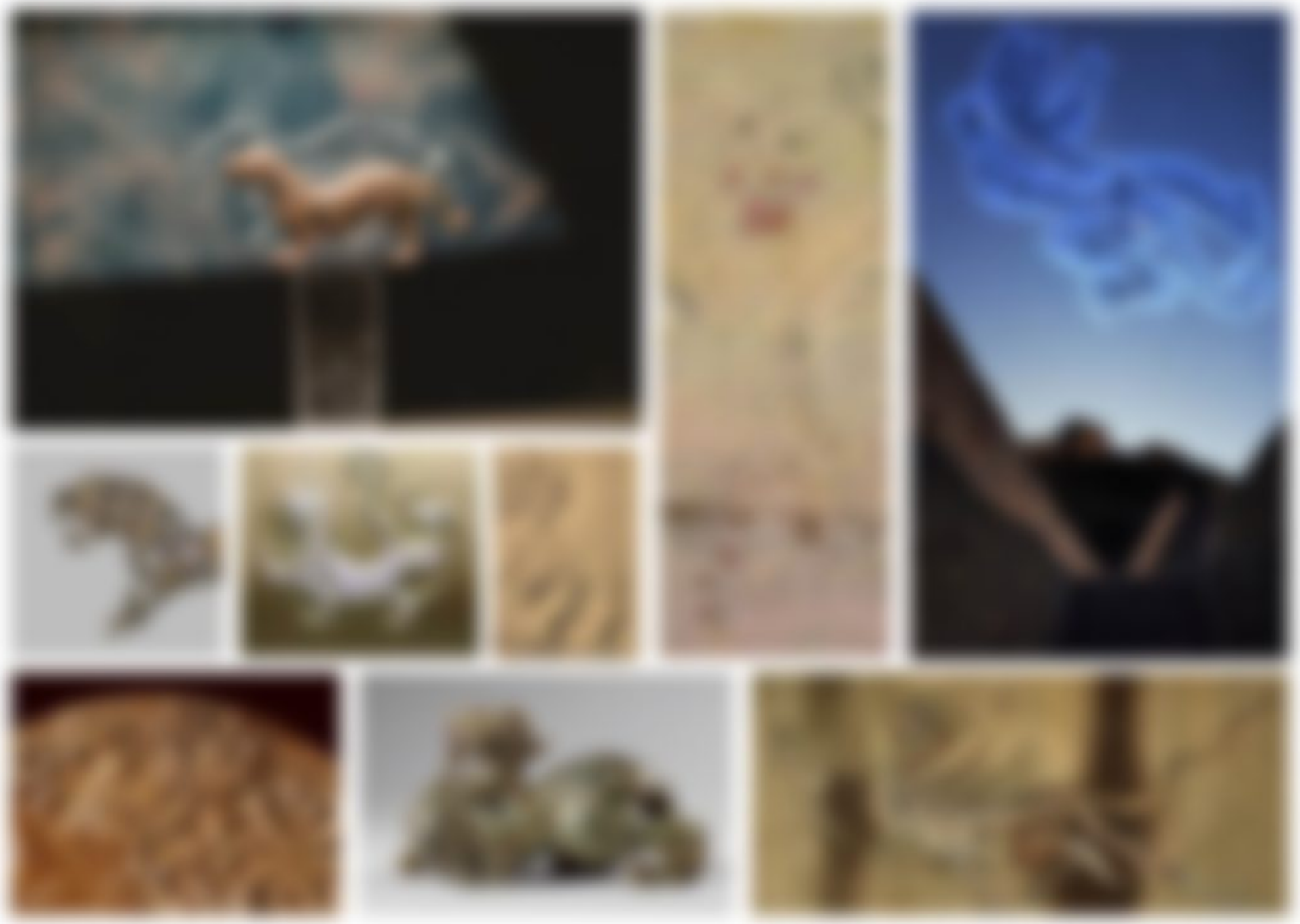
SLIDE 3 | China is, of course, no exception in the two disciplines mentioned above. It is even in the pantheon of the most excellent astronomers and astrologers and the wealthiest discoveries.

Exploring the countless documents published on this matter, one quickly notices the predominance of drawings made by these explorers of the sky: lines that link the sky's stars to each other to form strange designs that seem to move across the sky from one season to another.

These are the constellations.











The Myth of the Androgyne

From Lan Caihe to Fen-Ma Liuming, from cosmogonies to eschatologies.

SLIDE 1 | The myth of the androgynous refers to any being not knowing any gender division. Thus, to a being who has integrated both its feminine and masculine energies, regardless of gender.

This myth knows no spatial or temporal boundaries. It has a powerful meaning on the cosmogonic and eschatological levels.

To use the mythologist Mircea Eliade's terms, one must note that the Antiquity made a noticeable distinction between the 'concrete hermaphrodite' and the 'ritual androgynous'.

The hermaphrodite showed substantial signs of both genres and was - mistakenly - considered to be the work of angry gods that, thus, should be destroyed. The ritual androgyne, on the contrary, was a mythic being that united the magical and religious powers inherent in both sexes.

Some deities were considered androgynous, and humans cross-dressed during rituals to receive the magical power of the androgynous, powerful in its primordial unity.

SLIDE 2 | It is interesting to note that in China, ornaments were worn as much by men as by women. Has this tradition and fashion changed over time, and centuries?

The question arises, and already reveals the beginnings of interesting answers to be explored in greater depth. In contemporary magazines, especially those dedicated to fashion, there are many illustrations of male figures wearing jewellery that - in some European countries - could not be considered by men.

History, in some countries of the world, has in fact fragmented and gendered the wearing of jewellery. Many pieces of fine jewellery are worn mainly by women, and some pieces of fine watches are worn mainly by men. Sometimes for the simple reason that the gaze of others prevails over our fascination with a work of craftsmanship that knows no gender, but the expression of precious heritages and know-how...



Chinese adornments *&* the *non-finito* of femininity

Adornments as moving extensions of our aura

SLIDE 1 | Ornaments are not simply jewellery for aesthetic purposes that could be called "art for art's sake". They hold symbolic powers, powers of revelation, of increasing the aura, or of protection, which vary and evolve according to the spatio-temporal context observed and the beings who wear them.

China has a very rich and ancient heritage in terms of the history of ornaments, depending on the period, the province and the social strata, as well as a very precious know-how and creativity that have given rise to sublime ornaments that can still be admired today.

SLIDE 2 | In its rich and surprising history, Hong Kong is also home to stories that keep the myth of the androgynous alive. Here are some of them whose works were exhibited at the Ambiguously Yours exhibition a few years ago in Hong Kong.









